



— OCEAN EXPEDITION

Swim with Humpback Whales in Tonga

8 days in the Kingdom of Tonga with marine scientist and ocean cinematographer Jono Allen. Small group. Private vessel. Face-to-face with the gentle giants.

DURATION

8 Days / 7 Nights

LOCATION

Vava'u, Tonga

GROUP SIZE

Max 7 Guests

FROM

US\$4,900

HIGHLIGHTS

Tonga, like you've never seen it



5 Days with Humpback Whales

Full days on a private vessel with expert guides, swimming alongside humpbacks in their breeding grounds.



Photography Masterclasses

Hands-on underwater photography guidance from Jono, plus a dedicated editing session on your final day.



Marine Science Expertise

Jono's background as an environmental scientist means you'll understand whale behaviour, not just observe it.



All-Inclusive Dining

Every meal covered. Traditional Tongan welcome feast, daily breakfasts, lunches on the boat, and group dinners by an award-winning chef.



Cultural Immersion

Paluki's island tour with stories of Tongan heritage, secret beaches, hidden lookouts, and the rich local culture of Vava'u.



Beyond the Whales

Coral reefs, blue caves, isolated white beaches, and the incredible underwater world of Vava'u between whale encounters.

ABOUT THE EXPERIENCE

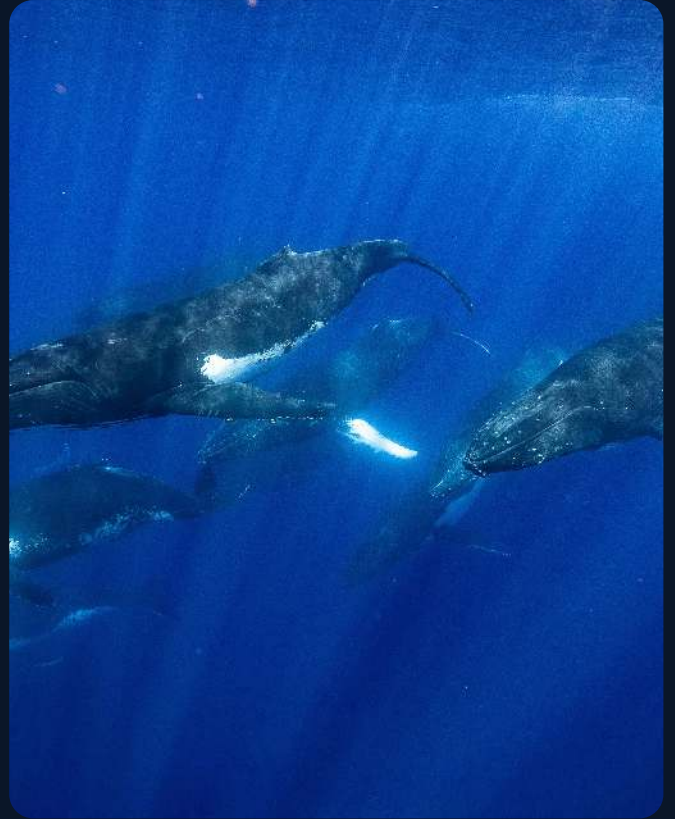
An expedition, not a tour

Join Jono and a small group of ocean-loving travellers in the remote island group of Vava'u, Kingdom of Tonga, where humpback whales return each year to mate, calve, and raise their young in warm, crystal-clear waters.

Each day you'll board a private vessel with expert guides and experienced skippers to find and swim alongside these extraordinary animals. This isn't a crowded whale-watching trip where you glimpse a tail from a distance. You'll be in the water, face-to-face, watching a mother and calf pass beneath you.

Between whale encounters, you'll drop anchor over vibrant coral reefs, explore blue caves and deserted beaches, and get to know the landscape both above and below the surface. Evenings are spent back at your ocean-view accommodation sharing stories over meals prepared by the resort's award-winning chef.

This trip is for anyone who feels at home in the water. Whether you're a photographer, freediver, or simply someone who's always dreamed of swimming with whales, the only prerequisite is that you're a confident snorkeller.



"The whales were mind blowing. What a gift to be in Tonga staring into the eye of a baby whale. This trip was a lifelong dream come true. We've already signed up again for next year."

Laura Cottril · Tonga 2023 guest, United States

YOUR STORYTELLER GUIDE

Jono Allen

Environmental scientist, marine megafauna guide, and ocean cinematographer. Jono's knowledge and years in the water get you as close as possible to these creatures, creating encounters most people only dream about.

This isn't a tourist whale-watching tour. Jono rejects the "smile-for-the-camera" approach. He guides you on a journey of exploration and understanding. You'll learn about humpback physiology, behaviour, and individual personalities. Every encounter is immersive, enlightening, and deeply personal.

Jono is also committed to the local Tongan community of Vava'u. By working with local services, staff, cuisine, and accommodations, your experience maintains authenticity while directly supporting the people and place that make it all possible.



WHY BOOK THIS EXPERIENCE?

Beyond a whale tour

Most whale tours in Tonga give guests a single brief swim, share the water with large groups, and rush through the day. One encounter isn't enough to truly

connect with these animals.

This trip is built differently. Five full days on the water with the same small group, learning to read whale behaviour, moving calmly and respectfully in the water, and letting genuine encounters unfold naturally rather than chasing the next tick-box moment.

With private charters and a maximum of seven guests, you get time and space in the water that a public tour simply can't offer. For photographers, it's ideal: Jono provides hands-on guidance throughout the trip, from shooting technique to editing your best frames on the final day.

By slowing the pace and keeping the experience personal, this week-long expedition removes the rush of a one-day tour and lets you truly immerse yourself in Tonga's incredible marine world.



DAY BY DAY

Your Itinerary

DAY

1

Welcome to Vava'u

Dive into Humpback Heaven

A private driver meets you at Vava'u airport and takes you to your water-view accommodation. Meet Jono and your fellow travellers over lunch, where he'll share his work in marine conservation and underwater photography. Settle into Vava'u's slower pace with a free afternoon, then gather for a traditional Tongan welcome feast at sunset. The evening wraps with Jono's masterclass on humpback behaviour and responsible interaction.

DAY

2

Sunday, Day of Rest

Embrace Tongan Tranquility

Sunday is sacred in Tonga. A relaxed breakfast, then time to dial in your snorkel gear in the crystalline waters. In the afternoon, Paluki's island tour takes you to lookouts, secret beaches, and the best of Vava'u, with stories of Tongan culture along the way. Recharge for the adrenaline-filled days ahead.

DAYS

3-7

Whale Odyssey

Daily Encounters with the Gentle Giants

Five full days on the water. Each morning you board your private vessel for ~7 hours of whale spotting along rugged coastlines, scanning for spouts, breaches, and tails. When the moment comes, you slip into the water for safe, guided swimming with humpbacks. Lunch anchored over coral reefs, with time to explore blue caves and isolated beaches. Evenings back at the resort with group dinners prepared by an award-winning chef.

DAY

8

Farewell, Vava'u

Turning Experiences into Lasting Captures

A morning masterclass with Jono on editing your whale photography, applying everything you've learned during the trip. Exchange farewells with your travel companions, then a private transfer back to Vava'u airport. 'Alu a!



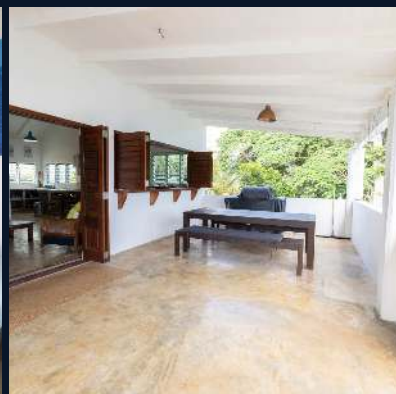
YOUR ACCOMMODATION

Your Island Home

Your base for the week is a water-front property on the island of Vava'u, with a private jetty and direct ocean access. Wake up to water views each morning and step straight out to the sea.

The accommodation is comfortable and authentic to the island setting. Spacious rooms with ensuite, open-plan living areas that flow onto covered verandahs, and communal lounges where your group gathers each evening. Private rooms are available on request.

All meals are prepared on-site by award-winning chef Andrea, using fresh seasonal produce. Evenings are spent sharing stories from the day's encounters over dinner with your group.



ON THE WATER

Zuzu

Your private vessel is Zuzu, a custom-built boat less than two years old, purpose-designed for whale encounters in Tonga's waters.

Equipped with a small onboard toilet and the latest safety gear, she's built for comfortable full days at sea.

At the helm is skipper Alastair "Al" Coldrick, with over 20 years of experience on these waters. Al partners with one of the best whale guides in Vava'u to ensure you're in the right place at the right time, every day.

With a maximum of seven guests, you have plenty of space on board and in the water. Lunch is served anchored over coral reefs, with time to explore blue caves and isolated beaches between whale encounters.



"The Airguides trip to Tonga to swim with humpback whales was the experience of a lifetime. I have traveled all over the world, and nothing compares. A wonderful and caring team made our adventures stress free. So much so, I am doing it again this year!"

THE PEOPLE BEHIND THE EXPERIENCE

Your Crew



Jono Allen

Storyteller Guide

Underwater photographer, environmental scientist, and marine megafauna guide. Your expert for every whale encounter.



Eva

Expedition Guide

Skilled freediver and hospitality expert. Eva ensures every detail is taken care of so you can fully immerse yourself in the experience.



Andrea

Professional Chef

Award-winning chef. Winner of Tonga's Best Chef Competition 2021. Prepares vibrant, fresh meals using seasonal local produce.



Paluki

Cultural Guide

Born and raised in Tonga. Shares the stories, customs, and hidden gems of Vava'u. Your connection to authentic Tongan culture.



Paul Rowsthorn

Expedition Director

Founder of Airguides. Handles all logistics, travel planning, and coordination so all you have to do is show up.

THE DETAILS

What's Included

Included

- 8 days / 7 nights ocean-view accommodation
- 5 full days of private vessel whale encounters (~7 hours/day)
- All meals: welcome feast, daily breakfasts, lunches on the boat, group dinners by award-winning chef
- Private airport transfers
- Storyteller guide Jono Allen throughout
- Dedicated Airguides Expedition Leader on-ground
- Marine biologist and in-water guides on charters
- Snorkelling equipment
- Photography masterclass and editing session
- Paluki's island cultural tour
- Personalised gallery of your best trip photos

Not Included

- International flights to Vava'u (VAV)
- Travel insurance (required)
- Personal expenses and gratuities
- Alcoholic beverages

QUESTIONS?

Frequently Asked

Do I need to be a photographer?

Not at all. This trip is hosted by a professional photographer and ocean guide, so they'll be available to take photos from your week. We find even people who call themselves "not a photographer" get a lot out of the sessions and learn a lot. For anyone interested in upskilling, you'll have masterclasses and the chance to ask questions from Jono and our team of professionals.

How do I get to Vava'u?

Our team will assist you with this process. In summary, most flights go via Nadi, Fiji from destinations like Australia, USA, and Singapore. Fiji Airways is the best airline to use. Once you're booked, we'll help coordinate your travel.

Is everything included?

Yes. This is a truly all-inclusive experience. Accommodation, all meals, private boat charters, airport transfers, guides, equipment, masterclasses, and cultural tours are all covered. The only extras are flights, travel insurance, personal expenses, and alcohol.

Can I get a private room?

Absolutely. You can select a private room at the time of booking.

Are private or group weeks available?

Yes. We offer both scheduled group departures and fully private weeks for families, friends, or corporate groups. Contact us at paul@airguides.com for options.

INVESTMENT

Pricing & Dates

US\$4,900

per person, all-inclusive

Secure your spot with a **US\$1,000 deposit**. Balance due 90 days prior to arrival.

2027 SEASON

July to September

DEPARTURES

10 small-group trips

Check the website for current dates and availability. Maximum 7 guests per departure. Smaller private weeks available on request.

READY?

Secure Your Spot

Spaces are limited. Get in touch to check availability and reserve your place with a US\$1,000 deposit.

Enquire Now

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